Four-day week pilot: report to the board

Executive summary

Acme should extend the four-day week pilot with conditions. It should not make the pilot permanent yet or end it.

Sick days fell 37.6% during the pilot [1]. Total output and on-time delivery were maintained or slightly higher, although output per person was flat to slightly lower [1]. A four-day week has fewer working days, and the file does not define sick days [1]. Part of the fall may therefore be mechanical. Staff wellbeing improved on four of five survey measures [2]. Customer service scored lowest on job satisfaction in June (3.1, against 4.0 and 4.1 elsewhere), and Friday cover is thin [2][3]. Whether its score improved is unknown.

The evidence covers six months and has no control group. That is too little for a permanent decision. We recommend at least six more months, a Friday-cover fix first and an agreed decision test.

Background

Acme Widgets Ltd ran a four-day week pilot at its single British site from January to June 2026. This report compares it with the six months before (July to December 2025). It uses three internal files: operations data [1], a staff wellbeing survey summary [2] and the operations manager's issues log [3]. All data is fictional test data.

Findings

Output, customer service and absence

Sick days fell from 420 to 262 (-37.6%) [1], the largest change, but the measure may not be comparable (see Limitations). Total units shipped rose 2.6%, but average headcount rose from about 49 to about 51 [1]. Output per person was therefore flat to slightly lower (-0.8%) [1]. On-time delivery averaged 94.45%, against 93.12% before [1]. Complaints fell from 90 to 76 (-15.6%) [1].

Table 1: Before and after the pilot

Measure	Before	Pilot	Change	Source
Units shipped, total	60,870	62,430	+2.6%	[1]
Units per head per month	207.0	205.4	-0.8%	[1]
On-time delivery, average	93.12%	94.45%	+1.33 points	[1]
Customer complaints, total	90	76	-15.6%	[1]
Sick days, total	420	262	-37.6%	[1]
Job satisfaction (score)	3.2	3.9	+0.7	[2]
Burnout (score; higher is better)	2.7	3.6	+0.9	[2]
Work-life balance (score)	2.9	4.1	+1.2	[2]
Workload is manageable (score)	3.1	3.0	-0.1	[2]
Would recommend Acme as employer (score)	3.4	4.0	+0.6	[2]

Source: operations data [1] and survey summary [2]. Totals, averages and percentages are calculated from [1]; on-time delivery is an unweighted monthly average. Operations figures compare July to December 2025 with January to June 2026; survey scores (1 to 5, five best) compare December 2025 with June 2026.

Wellbeing

Wellbeing improved overall, but "workload is manageable" did not (3.1 to 3.0) [2]. In June 2026, customer service scored lowest on job satisfaction: 3.1, against 4.1 for production and 4.0 for warehouse [2]. No earlier team scores exist, so we cannot tell if customer service was already lower or has improved [2].

Problems and causes

Friday customer-service cover is the one recurring problem. In April, customer service raised concerns: one person covers Fridays, phone queue times rose and no extra hire was made [3]. In June, complaints rose to 18 from nine in May [1]. Most related to slow Friday responses during a recall notice issued on a Thursday [3]. The operations manager judged it mostly a one-off but linked it to thin Friday cover [3]. Six survey comments, five from customer service, described stressful Friday cover [2]. In January, output dipped slightly during a two-week planning adjustment [3].

Limitations

- **No control group.** Headcount rose from 50 to 51 in March (role not stated) [1]. Meetings were also shortened and planning moved to Monday to Thursday [3]. The data cannot separate these effects from the four-day week.
- **Sick-day comparability.** A four-day week has fewer working days, and the file does not define sick days [1]. The counts may not be comparable, so the fall may be partly mechanical.
- **Different seasons.** The periods cover different halves of the year, and no earlier-year data exists [1].
- **A weak baseline.** December 2025 was the worst month on all four operations measures. Without it, units rose 1.2% and on-time delivery improved by 1.09 points. Sick days still fell, from 67.2 to 43.7 a month on average [1].
- **Survey limits.** We have a summary only. The survey is anonymous, so respondents may differ between rounds. Response rates were 82% in December 2025 and 73% in June 2026, and the nine (December) and 14 (June) non-respondents may differ from respondents. The customer service result rests on eight respondents [2].
- **Missing data.** The files give no queue times, Friday results, costs, pay or hours worked, so output per hour cannot be assessed. They do not define on-time delivery or sick days. The cause of the June rise is one manager's judgement [1][3].
- **Short period.** Six months cannot show whether June's rise in complaints is a one-off or a trend. No data exists after June [1].

Recommendation

Extend the pilot for at least six months, with these conditions. This is a judgement, not a data result; confidence is medium. The data favours the four-day week, but the gaps argue for more evidence before it becomes permanent.

Conditions

1. Fix Friday customer-service cover before any permanent change [3], ideally by the start of the extension. Our suggestions: a second person on Fridays or a defined escalation route. The files give no costs.
2. Plan for urgent Friday notices, such as the June recall [3].
3. Collect monthly operations data from July 2026, complaints and response times by weekday, and repeat team surveys with response rates.
4. Set a fall-back. If Friday cover cannot be fixed or complaints keep rising, redesign or end the pilot.

Decision test. Move to permanent status only if, at the end of the extension:

- complaints stay at or below the pilot average of 12.67 a month [1]
- no month reaches June's 18 complaints [1]
- sick days stay well below the earlier average of 70 a month [1]
- customer service job satisfaction moves towards other teams (3.1, against 4.0 and 4.1) [2]

The board should set the exact thresholds.

References

[1] Acme Widgets Ltd (Operations). (2026). *Acme Widgets Ltd monthly operations data* (`pilot-metrics.csv`). Internal export from the ops dashboard, exported 3 July 2026. File: `projects/example-acme-pilot/00-brief/pilot-metrics.csv` (accessed 14 October 2026).

[2] Acme Widgets Ltd (Human resources, HR). (2026). *Staff wellbeing survey summary* (`staff-survey-summary.md`). Internal summary, prepared 5 July 2026. File: `projects/example-acme-pilot/00-brief/staff-survey-summary.md` (accessed 14 October 2026).

[3] Acme Widgets Ltd (Operations manager). (2026). *Pilot issues log* (`manager-notes.md`). Internal notes, January to June 2026. File: `projects/example-acme-pilot/00-brief/manager-notes.md` (accessed 14 October 2026).